

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1994-03-24

To all National Spiritual Assemblies in Europe

HeAr TS grieved p ASSiNg deArly loved STAlw ArT mAidServ ANT bAhá'u'lláh doro Thy ferrAby whoSe diSTiNguiShed ServiceS cA uSe god exTeNded over more ThAN hAlf A ceNTury. She coNTribuTed SigNificANTly AdmiNiS-TrATioN f AiTh AS member NATioNAL ASSEMBly briTiSh iSleS AND firST Auxil-iAry bo Ard europe, pl Ayed viTAl p ArT hiST oric AfricA cAmp AigN l AuNched by Shoghi effeNdi, Served world ceNTER duriNg cuST odiANShip hANDS cAuSe, AND l ATer AS member coNTiNeNTAl bo Ard of couNselorS europe. TheSe ServiceS, AS well AS her iNdef ATigAble l AborS AND STerliNg qu Ali-TieS, her TeNA ciTy, perSeverANce AND uNfliNchiNg loyAl Ty hA ve eNriched ANNAIS f AiTh briTiSh iSleS AND SeT wor Thy exAmple.

ArdeNTly prA yiNg holy ShriNeS progreSS her Noble Soul Abhá kiNg-dom. Advise hold memoriAl gATheriNgS commuNiTieS uNiTed kiNgdom. 177 .5
177 .6

178.1

178.2

1993–1996 • T h e T h r e e Y e a r P l a n

75requeSTiNg NATioNAL SpiriTu Al ASSEMBly of germANY hold A memoriAl Ser-vice mo Ther Temple europe. AlSo AdvisiNg europeAN NATioNAL ASSEMBlieS hold commemorATive gATheriNgS commuNiTieS Their couNTrieS. coNvey our loviNg Symp AThy her beloved dA ughTer, o Ther memberS her f Amily.

Universal HoUse of JUstice

179

Murder of Three Iranian Pioneers to South Africa

28 m arch 1994

To all National Spiritual Assemblies

dear b ahá'í f riends,

with you certain details relevant to the murder of three iranian bahá'í pioneers to South Africa for the information of the friends throughout the world. As you may have learned from the wide publicity which the incident received, on 13 march mr. houshmand Anvari, dr. Shamam bakhshandegi and mr. riaz razavi were shot to death by gunmen who burst into the bahá'í center at mdantsane, ciskei, where some adults and children had gathered for meetings. mr. Anvari, who served as caretaker of the bahá'í center, had been painting a portion of the building when four young gun-men ordered him to go inside at a time when children's classes were ending and the friends were preparing for a meeting concerning the international year of the family. mr. razavi, Auxiliary board member for ciskei, and dr. bakhshandegi had been invited especially to consult with the friends at this meeting. The gunmen ordered the "whites," these three iranian friends, to stand apart from the others, lined them up against the wall with their hands above their heads, searched them, and then fired at them with automatic weapons as their fellow believers looked on in utter shock. The gunmen fled immediately, using mr. razavi's car to get away. mr. razavi and mr. Anvari were killed instantly; dr. bakhshandegi died upon arrival at a hospital in mdantsane.

The three deceased friends lived in South Africa near the border with ciskei and focused their bahá'í services on that homeland. mr. razavi, 44, director of finance at the university of fort hare in ciskei, pioneered in 178.3

179.1

179.2

179.3

m e S S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

761976 to lesotho where two years later he married vera paquay, a belgian pioneer, and in 1979 was elected to the National Spiritual Assembly. in 1983 the razavi family moved to king william's Town in South Africa from which in subsequent years mr. razavi focused his attention on ciskei as a bahá'í teacher and then as an Auxiliary board member since August 1989. he is survived by his wife, vera, their 15-year-old son, jalal, and 12-year-old daughter, r ouhieh.

mr. Anvari, 43, a computer programmer, first went to the united States

from his native iran to complete his studies, and in 1990 journeyed with his family to South Africa for the second time, settling in east london in order to serve both in South Africa and ciskei. he and his wife dina established a crèche at the bahá'í center in mdantsane and also founded a weekend tutorial school in king william's Town. mr. Anvari was a member of the local Spiritual Assembly of east london and engaged in public relations work for the faith. he also served as caretaker /manager of the mdantsane bahá'í center where he was killed. he has left behind his wife and their three young children: v affa, 8; Nava, 5; and Ava, 2.

dr. bakhshandegi, 28, a dentist, served on the staff of the cecilia makwani hospital in mdantsane, ciskei, as supervisor of the community dental section. he was born in mauritania where his parents were pioneers, and spent his years as a child and youth there, becoming a brilliant student, and eventually attaining proficiency in five languages. in the early 1980s he went as a pioneer to South Africa with his parents, dr. Amin bakhshandegi, also a dentist, and mrs. badri bakhshandegi. while a university student in johannesburg for several years, he was a member of the local Spiritual Assembly. At the end of his studies, he returned to east london, where he served as secretary of the local Spiritual Assembly and as public relations officer for his region. just before his death dr. bakhshandegi had completed the first scientific dental research done in ciskei for which he will be awarded a master's degree posthumously. he had already won, along with two others, the elida ponds research Award in dentistry for his work. dr. bakhshandegi is survived by his parents and his sister, djam.

The killers have not yet been identified nor have their motives been clarified, but the view has been expressed in press reports that their action was racially motivated. The incident evoked condemnatory statements from officials of the South African government, the African National congress, and various religious communities. The South African National Spiritual Assembly reported unprecedented publicity of the faith in their country as

179.4

179.5

1993–1996 • T h e T h r e e Y e a r P l a n

77a result. many of the published reports mention that the bahá'ís of South Africa have a 40-year history of multiracialism. Stories distributed by the wire services, the Associated press and reuters, have appeared in newspapers around the world. o ther international media have also carried reports. on 19 march, a dignified funeral service, attended by some five hundred people, was conducted at the town hall of a suburb of east london called cambridge. in addition to the bahá'ís who came from all over southern Africa as well as from many local communities in South Africa, the attendees included the mayor of east london, the chancellor and a member of the council of the university of fort hare, two members of the National party for that region and many other sympathizers from the public. in his eulogy the mayor of east london regarded these deaths as a sacrifice for peace and the unity of mankind. After several hours of prayers, readings from the Sacred Scriptures, eulogies and expressions of sympathy, the three bodies of these dearly loved and respected friends were taken to the cemetery and finally laid to rest side by side.

upon receiving news of this tragic incident from the National Spiritual Assembly of South Africa, the house of justice responded with the following message on 14 m arch:

Shocked grieved NewS violenT deATh houShmANd ANv Ari, ShAmA-
mbAkh ShANdegi AND riAz rAz Avi iN ciSkei. profouNdly impreSSed
STerliNg exAmple SeT by Their dedicATioN cA uSe bAhá'u'lláh iN
whoSe Service They were directLy eNgA ged wheN STRuck down
by ASSASSiNS' bulleTS. deeply Symp AThize irrep ArAble loSS Their
deAr f AmilieS AND frieNdS. mA y All heAr TS be comfor Ted by prom-
iSe bleSSed beA uTy ThAT They ThAT hA ve forSAkeN Their couNTry
iN p ATh god AND SubSequeNTly ASceNded uNT o hiS preSeNce ShAll
be bleSSed by coNcourSe oN high AND Their NAmES recorded by
peN glory AmoNg Such AS hA ve l Aid down Their liveS AS mAr TyrS
pATh god. coNfideNT joyouS welcome Abhá kiNgdom TheSe diS-
TiNguiShed SouLS. ArdeNTly prA yiNg holy ShriNeS Their progreSS
diviNe worldS. AlSo offeriNg SupplicATioNS behAlf All rel ATiveS
frieNdS. Advise hold memoriAl gATheriNgS Throug houT SouTh

Africa.

with loving b áhá'í greetings,

Department of the Secretariat 179.7

179.8

179.8a

Message from The Universal House of Justice

78180

Appointment of New Continental Counselor

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]